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6 **Research Topic** : The Association Between Screen Time and Burnout Among High School Students in Bangladesh: A Mixed-Methods Approach

The Association Between Screen Time and Burnout Among High School Students in Bangladesh: A Mixed-Methods Approach

1.1 Introduction

In today's rapidly digitalized world, the use of electronic devices has become deeply integrated into high school students' daily lives. From attending virtual classes to using social media, high school students use different kinds of devices, such as smartphones and computers. However, this phenomenon has increased the amount of screen time in their lives. Excessive screen time has raised concerns about its impact on students' mental health. One such concern is burnout – a state of mental, physical, and emotional exhaustion. Recent studies suggest that excessive screen time may be a significant contributing factor to this; yet, little research has been conducted in the context of Bangladesh, a country where academic competition is intense and awareness of mental health issues is still emerging. This study aims to explore the relationship between screen time and the experience of burnout among high school students in Bangladesh.

1.2 Background of the Study

[1] Adolescence represents a phase of increased risk for the emergence of mental health problems. [2] High school students, typically aged between 16 and 19, are in a development state that may involve increased vulnerability to mental health challenge.During adolescence, people are more likely to engage in risky, [3] reward-oriented, novelty-seeking behavior, particularly when these activities involve social component. [4] According to WHO, globally one in seven 10-19-year-olds experiences a mental disorder, accounting for 15% of the global burden of disease in this age group.

[5] The current generation of teenagers are called 'digital natives'. [6] The increased use of screens has been noticeable and amplified in the Covid-19 pandemic due to isolation and restrictions on other leisure activities. Even after Covid-19 pandemic, high school students continue to spend a significant amount of time on electronic devices. Instead of decreasing, their screen time has actually increased, largely due to the continued reliance on digital tools for education, communication and entertainment. [7] According to researchers, numerous physical and mental health conditions, including as headaches, sleep disorders, [8]-[9] and behavioral disorders, are linked to screen usage. Focusing on mental health, multiple global studies have established a growing concern that excessive screen time may be significantly associated with mental health issues, including emotional exhaustion, cognitive fatigue and academic burnout – especially among high school students.

Burnout in adolescents is characterized by persistent fatigue, reduced academic motivation and emotional detachment, often resulting from chronic stress and overwhelming demands. According to a 2023 study in the Journal of Adolescent Health, adolescents who spend more than 4 hours per day on screens are at a notably higher risk of experiencing burnout symptoms, largely due to sleep disruption, lack of physical activity and social isolation. [10] During July 2021 through December 2023, one-half of teenagers ages 12–17 had 4 hours or more of daily screen time (50.4%).

1.3 Statement of the Problem

Although there is a substantial research on mental health issues on high school students in western countries, very few studies have focused on the specific mental health issue called burnout in Bangladesh. In the context of Bangladesh, this issue is compound by academic

pressure, limited mental health support and widespread access to smartphones and social media. As online platforms became integral to both learning and leisure, many students report difficulty disconnecting from devices, leading to mental fatigue and lack of rest. [11] One study by the Bangladesh Educational Journal (2022) highlighted that over 60% of urban high school students reported increased screen time post- COVID, nearly half of them acknowledging difficulties in concentration and sleep – both indicators of emotional burnout.

Despite these findings, a clear, data-driven exploration of the correlation between screen time and experience of burnout among Bangladeshi high school students remains insufficient. This study aims to fill that gap by examining how screen use patterns and durations relate to mental exhaustion and burnout symptoms within this demographic.

1.4 Research Objectives

(a) To examine the relationship between screen time and burnout among high school students

(b) To determine which screen-usage patterns are the strongest predictors of student burnout

1.5 Research Questions

(a) Is there any significant association between screen time and burnout among high school students?

(b) What patterns of screen usage are most associated with student burnout?

1.6 Significance of the Study

With reference to the problem discussed, the present study addresses an emerging concern among high school students in Bangladesh: the relationship between increasing screen use and academic burnout. With the expansion of digital learning, online coaching, digital assignments, social media, and entertainment, students are spending a substantial portion of their daily lives in front of screens. The study therefore provides a timely examination of how different patterns of screen usage may be associated with students' emotional exhaustion, academic stress, and burnout.

The study is particularly significant because it moves beyond examining screen time merely in terms of the number of hours and considers the purposes and patterns of screen use. This suggests that the relationship between screen use and burnout cannot be understood simply by treating all screen activities as equivalent.

The quantitative finding will provide empirical evidence that higher average screen time is significantly associated with higher levels of burnout. The qualitative findings may further enrich this result by showing that prolonged screen use may be accompanied by feelings of guilt, mental haze, emotional detachment, and reduced productivity, while restorative activities such as sleep may provide greater cognitive recovery.

The study may also be useful to teachers, school administrators, parents and policymakers. Its findings can contribute to the development of more balanced digital-learning practices, reasonable screen-use guidelines, and school-based digital well-being initiatives. Rather than discouraging technology altogether, the findings suggest the importance of balancing academic screen exposure with adequate rest and healthy recovery practices.

Finally, the study contributes to the relatively limited body of research on screen usage and academic burnout among high school students in Bangladesh. It may provide a foundation for future research involving larger and more diverse student populations and more detailed investigation of specific screen-use patterns.

1.7 Limitations of the Study

Despite its contributions, the study has several limitations that might be considered when interpreting its findings. Some potential issues could be that participating students might not want to express their true feelings and experiences. They may become confused about their feelings as they are in their late teens and more likely to internalize their thoughts and emotions. Again, they might worry about getting their privacy leaked.

Also, there could be a chance of getting less response than expected. In that case, all the different experiences might not be collected since everyone is different.

These limitations can be controlled or handled by being careful and responsible while considering how things can be changed during the research. This will do a big help in ensuring accurate and reliable results.

The study is geographically limited. The participants will be selected from schools in the Uttara region of Dhaka. Consequently, the findings may not be fully generalizable to high school students in other parts of Bangladesh, particularly students from rural areas or from schools with different socioeconomic and educational backgrounds.

The quantitative data relied on students' self-reported information concerning screen use and burnout. Self-reported measures may be affected by recall errors, subjective perceptions or a tendency to overestimate or underestimate actual screen use.

1.8 Research Methodologies

This study will follow both qualitative and quantitative, cross-sectional survey-based design to examine the association between screen time and burnout levels among high school students in Bangladesh. A structured questionnaire will be used to collect data on screen time habits and self-reported burnout symptoms. Students will be assured of confidentiality and anonymity.

1.8.1 Quantitative Phase

A sample size of 250-300 high school students (16-19years) will be targeted to ensure adequate statistical power and generalizability of findings. A survey will be administered to participants to collect information about their daily screen time, type of screen use and experiences related to burnout (emotional exhaustion, academic fatigue, sleep quality and concentration issues etc.). Analyzing this data may help identify potential correlations between screen time usage and feelings of burnout.

1.8.2 Qualitative Phase

A subset of participants (n=20-25) will be selected for in depth semi-structured interviews. These interviews will explore more about high school students' burnout experiences. Thematic analysis will be used to identify key themes and patterns within information collected from interviews.

1.8.3 Data Analysis

Quantitative data will be assessed using descriptive statistics (mean, median) which will describe screen time and burnout levels. Inferential statistics, Pearson correlation will be used to test the association between screen time and burnout scores.

In the qualitative data analysis, interview transcripts will be examined using thematic analysis to identify common themes and patterns related to participants' burnout experiences.

1.8.4 Project Practicalities

The timeline has been carefully planned to gather all information needed. To accommodate both quantitative and qualitative phases, it will take 3 weeks to design a proper questionnaire and collect data. After collecting information, it will take 2 weeks to analyze the data and write the report.

It will be ensured that participants privacy, informed consent and the right to withdraw will be respected. Everyone's data will be protected by maintaining security measures. No personally identifying information will be collected. Every participant will voluntarily participate in the survey and the interview.

It is ensured that this research will be conducted fairly and privately. Recognized or established ethical guidelines will be adhered. Approaching the research in this manner will facilitate the collection of accurate data while ensuring a responsible and ethical process. Upholding participants' privacy and adhering to established ethical guidelines are fundamental principles that contribute to the study's credibility and reliability.

1.8.5 Post Program Plan

After the completion of data collection, analysis and report writing, significant steps will be taken to ensure that the findings are meaningfully shared, used and possibly expanded in future research or practical application. A summary or full report will be submitted to student journals or local platforms so that students, teachers and school authorities can raise awareness of the issue. This project may serve as a baseline study for a larger regional comparison. Future studies can be designed long term impacts of screen time on high school students' mental health.

1.9 Operational Definitions of the Terms

Burnout: Burn out (or burnout) means a state of extreme physical, mental, or emotional exhaustion caused by long-term, unmanaged stress.

Digital Burnout: Excessive screen time is a primary driver of digital burnout, a distinct form of mental, emotional, and physical exhaustion caused by prolonged exposure to digital devices.

High School Students: A high school student is a teenager enrolled in upper-secondary education, typically covering grades 9 through 12 and ages 14 to 19.

Screen Time: Screen time is the total amount of time a person spends looking at or interacting with an electronic display.

Screen Usage Pattern: A screen usage pattern is the habitual way a person interacts with digital devices—such as smartphones, computers, and televisions—measured by total duration, timing, specific apps used, and physical context.

1.10 Conclusion

In an increasingly digital world, screen time has become an inseparable part of students' academic and personal lives-especially in the context of post-pandemic Bangladesh. While digital tools have provided new opportunities for learning and connectivity, excessive screen use has also raised concerns about mental health among high school students who are already under academic and social pressure.

This research aims to explore the association between screens time and experiences of a specific mental health issue called "Burnout" among Bangladeshi high school students. By using a structured, evidence based approach, the study will shed light on how screen habits might be contributing to emotional and academic fatigue within this vulnerable age group.

Ultimately, this research intends not just identify a problem, but to encourage healthy screen habits, promote mental resilience, and support a more balanced and sustainable student lifestyle.

This study will investigate the relationship between screen usage and academic burnout among high school students in Bangladesh. The study was motivated by the increasing reliance on digital devices for academic activities, communication, social media, and entertainment, particularly following the COVID-19 pandemic. The research sought to examine whether the amount and patterns of screen use were associated with students' experiences of burnout and to identify the screen-use patterns most closely related to burnout.

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